

VANGUARD
COMICS



ISSUE

01

\$4.99 US
TEEN+

TENSION IS **REALITY**.



CONTROL IS **EVERYTHING**.

緊
張
TENSION



VANGUARD
HOLDING CELL

VC-23-07-REN



06185122



緊張は現実
制御はすべて



© 2024

SOME WOUNDS
DON'T **BLEED** RED.

A NEW SERIES BY



VANGUARD COMICS

VANGUARD HOLDING CELL 7A

MAXIMUM SECURITY

TENSION-DAMPENING FIELD: ACTIVE

TENSION IS
FREEDOM.

THEY CAN
DAMPEN
THE FIELD.
NOT ME.

RENN

- AGE: 16
- TENSION-CRAFT USER
- RIGHT EYE: BLIND
- RIGHT ARM: NONFUNCTIONAL
- STATUS: DETAINED

DAY 03.

STILL NO RESPONSE.
THE FIELD'S THICKER
THAN ANYTHING I'VE
EVER FELT.



PULLED.
STRUCK.
COUNTERED.
ADAPTED.

AGAIN.
AND AGAIN.
AND AGAIN.

EVERY
LESSON.

EVERY
SCAR.

FOR THIS.

HAH...

HAH...

HAH...

STILL
DOESN'T
BUDGE.

NOTHING
I DO...

...WILL
MAKE IT
OPEN.

FIGHTING
WON'T OPEN
THIS DOOR.

THAT'S THE
TRUTH.

AND THAT
TRUTH...

...HURTS
MORE
THAN ANY
HIT.

ALL THIS
TENSION...

ALL THIS
TRAINING...

...AND I'M
STILL JUST
A KID...

IN A CELL.

SO WHAT
NOW,
RENN?



TENSION-
CRAFT
CELL.

THIRD
SUB-LEVEL.

NO EXIT.

I WON'T
STAY HERE!



KRRK
KRRK



LET ME
OUT!

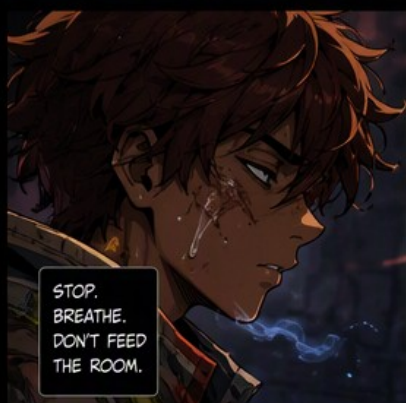
I'LL TEAR
THIS APART!

THIS IS
MINE!



RRGH!

KRAAAAANG!



STOP.
BREATHE.
DON'T FEED
THE ROOM.

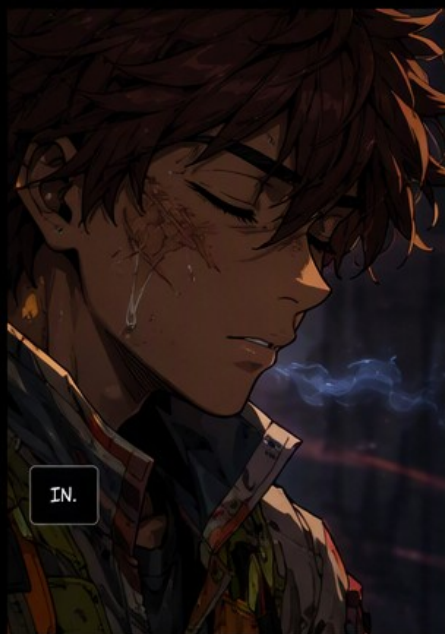


EVERY STRUGGLE
FEEDS THE ROOM.

EVERY BURST
OF FORCE
TIGHTENS
THE SPOOL.

I'M NOT JUST
FIGHTING THEM—

I'M FEEDING
THEM.



IN.



OUT.



THE LINES
SOFTEN.

THE WALLS
BLUR.

THE ROOM
LETS GO.

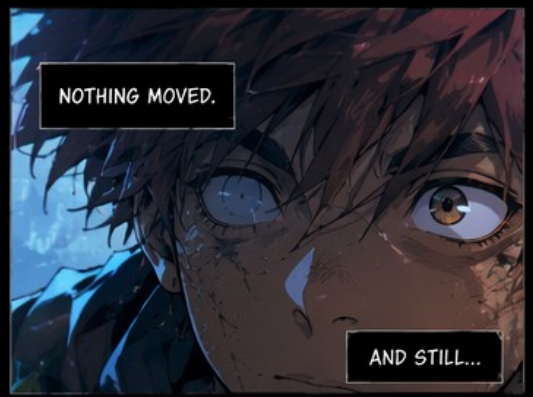
SO DO I.



THE ROOM IS EXACTLY
AS IT WAS.

AND YET—

...SOMETHING
HAS SLIPPED.



NOTHING MOVED.

AND STILL...



...EVERYTHING
DID.



THE SOUND
IS HERE—

KREEEE--

CHHHT--

—BUT IT'S
NOT THERE.



THE EDGES
OF THE WORLD
UNRAVEL.

MY THOUGHTS
DETACH.



I AM HERE.

BOTH.
NEITHER.

NO—
I AM
THERE.



IT'S NOT
PAIN.

IT'S NOT
FEAR.

IT'S...



PERCEPTUAL
SHIFT.

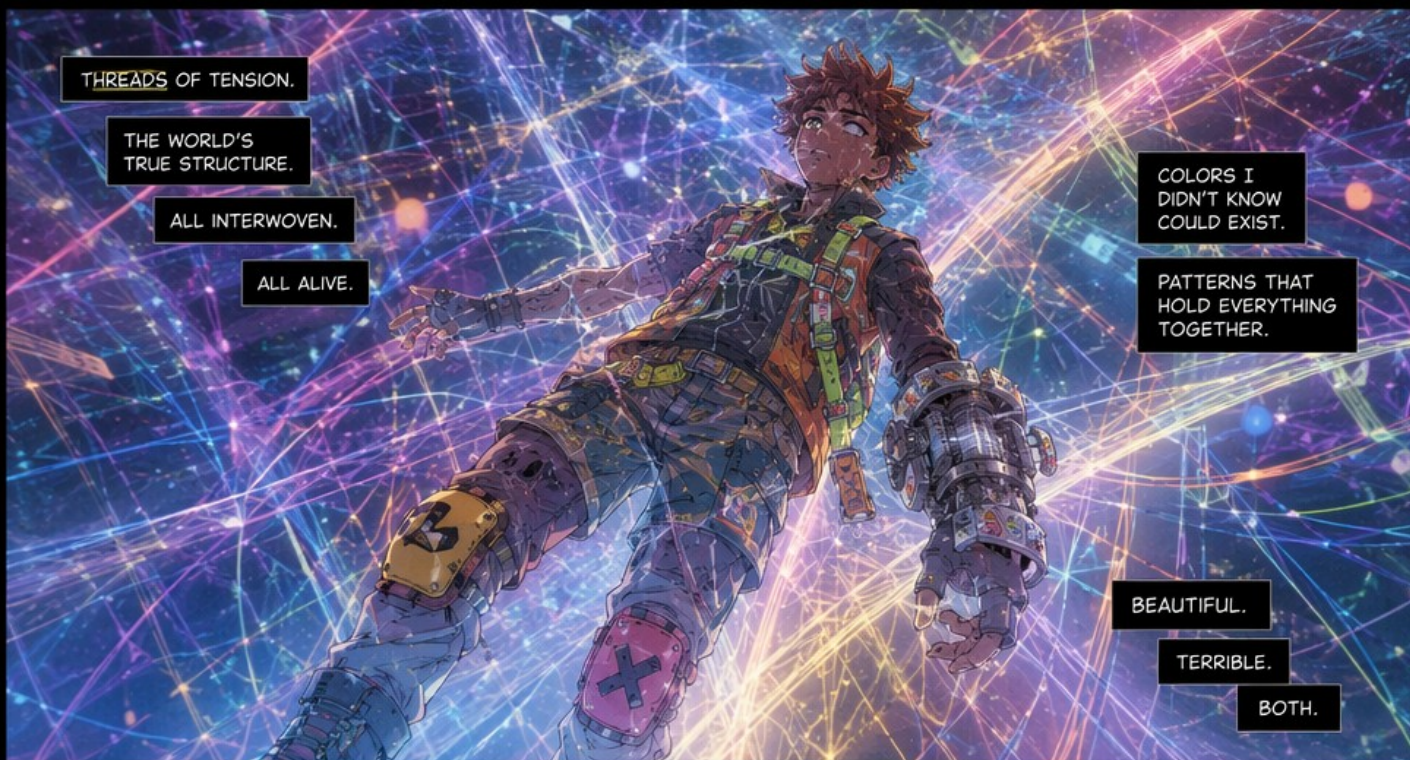


I FELL.

NOT DOWN.

THROUGH.

LAYER AFTER LAYER.



THREADS OF TENSION.

THE WORLD'S
TRUE STRUCTURE.

ALL INTERWOVEN.

ALL ALIVE.

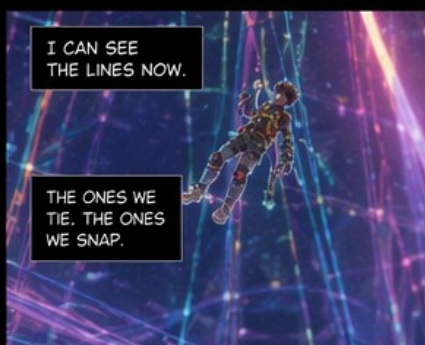
COLORS I
DIDN'T KNOW
COULD EXIST.

PATTERNS THAT
HOLD EVERYTHING
TOGETHER.

BEAUTIFUL.

TERRIBLE.

BOTH.



I CAN SEE
THE LINES NOW.

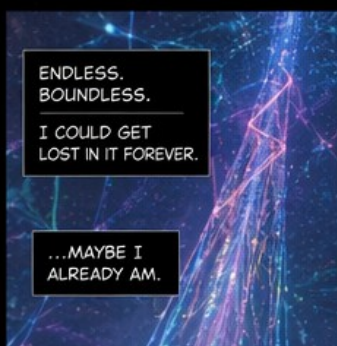
THE ONES WE
TIE. THE ONES
WE SNAP.



EVERY PULL.
EVERY CHOICE.



IT ALL
ECHOES HERE.



ENDLESS.
BOUNDLESS.
I COULD GET
LOST IN IT FOREVER.

...MAYBE I
ALREADY AM.



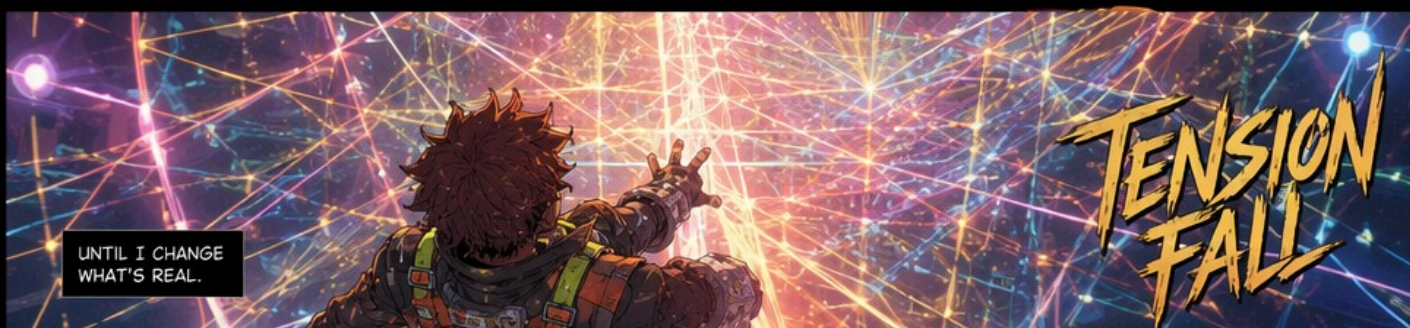
BUT SOMEWHERE
UP THERE...

SOMEONE'S
HOLDING THE
OTHER END.



SO I'LL
KEEP FALLING.

UNTIL I FIND THEM.



UNTIL I CHANGE
WHAT'S REAL.

TENSION FALL





THE KNOTMASTER.

THEIR SMOCK IS
WOVEN OF RUNNING
PIGMENTS AND
LIQUID LIGHT.

THEIR RIGHT ARM:
MUSICAL WEFT-THREAD.
VIBRATES LIKE
HARP STRINGS.

RENN.

SIXTEEN.
ONE EYE GONE.
ONE ARM GONE.
LEFT ARM:
TENSION-GAUNTLET
SPOOL.

STILL CLIMBING.
STILL HERE.



THEY PLUCK
A STRAY THREAD
THE WAY OTHERS
CRACK KNUCKLES.



RENN
WATCHES.

NOT IN AWE.
NOT IN FEAR.
JUST...
SURPRISED.



STRAY
THREAD.
BAD HABIT.

KEEPS ME
FROM TYING
MYSELF INTO
SOMETHING
TIGHTER.

YOU EVER
GET YOURSELF
TIED TOO TIGHT,
KNOTMASTER?

MORE TIMES
THAN I CAN
COUNT.

THAT'S HOW
YOU LEARN
WHERE TO
LEAVE ROOM.



...SOUND
LIKE CLIMBING.

LEAVE ROOM,
OR YOU DON'T
MAKE THE
NEXT MOVE.



HEH.

YOU GET IT,
RENN.

YOU GET IT.

THE WEFT DRIFTS.
THE CONVERSATION
CONTINUES.
THREAD BY THREAD.

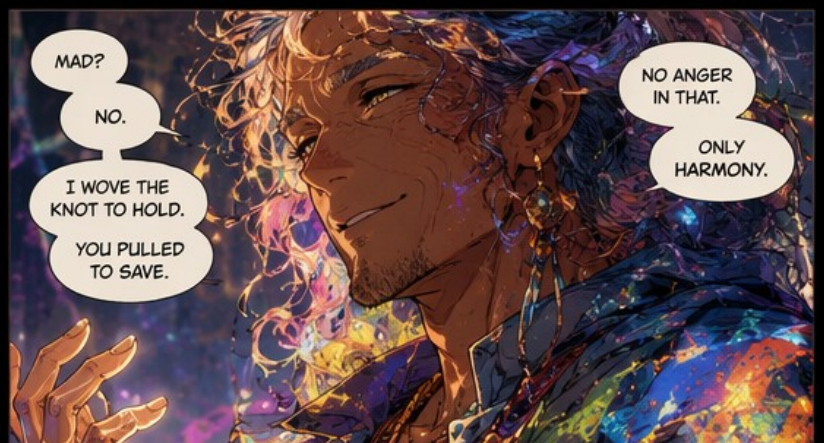


THE SCRAP-PENDULUM.

HELD IN PLACE BY
A GRAVITY-NET WOVEN
OF LIGHT AND SONG.

STABLE FOR THREE
SEASONS. SINCE THE
KNOTMASTER WOVE
THE FINAL KNOT.

SO THIS IS
WHAT'S BEEN
HOLDING IT ALL
TOGETHER...



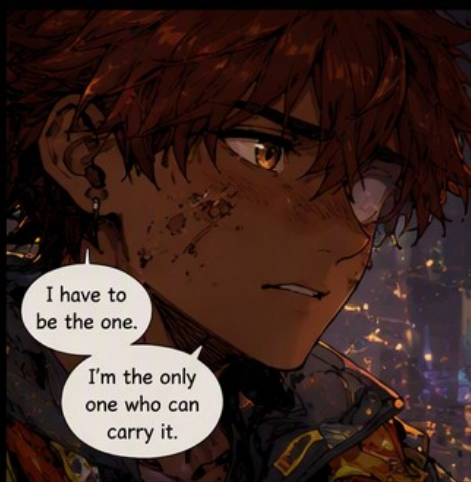


You're still holding it so tight.

Like it'll slip if you breathe.

If I don't... someone else gets hurt.

That's how it works.



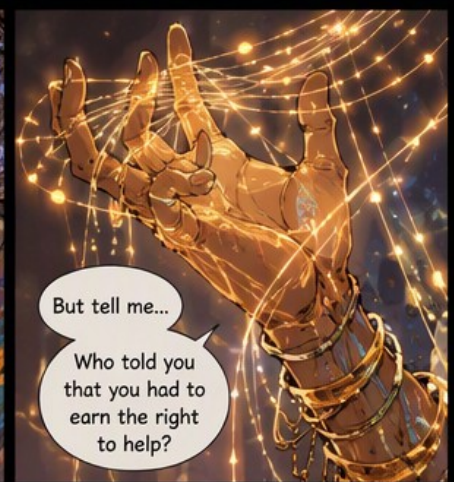
I have to be the one.

I'm the only one who can carry it.



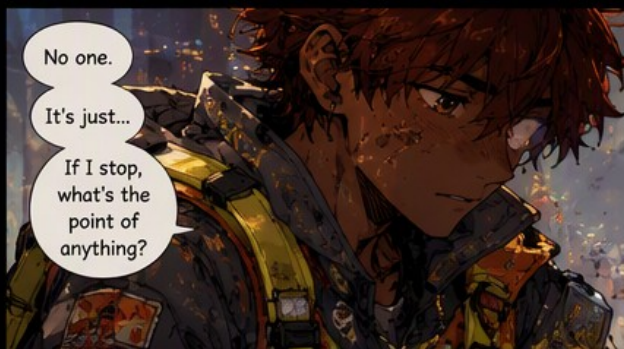
Mhm.

You've been carrying it a long time, Renn.



But tell me...

Who told you that you had to earn the right to help?



No one.

It's just...

If I stop, what's the point of anything?



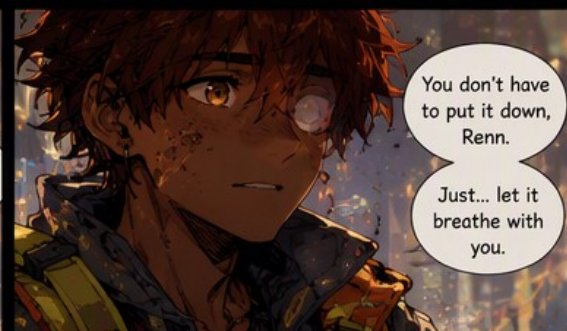
Ah.

So the weight has become your reason for standing.



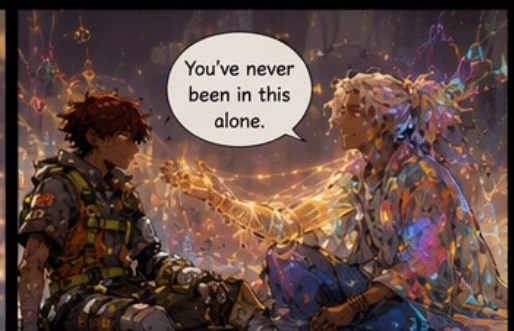
But reasons can change shape.

That doesn't mean they weren't real.



You don't have to put it down, Renn.

Just... let it breathe with you.



You've never been in this alone.



You just forgot.

THE WEFT

BOOK 2: TENSION
CHAPTER 17: LINKNOT

THE KNOT DOESN'T
FIGHT WHEN YOU
STOP PULLING.

IT REMEMBERS
WHERE IT
BELONGS.



TENSION ISN'T
SOMETHING YOU WIN.

IT'S SOMETHING
YOU UNDERSTAND.

—KNOTMASTER



...DRIFTING
OUT OF
SOMETHING
THAT WASN'T
QUITE ME.

THREADS
UNWIND.

STATIC
WITHOUT
SIGNAL.



THE TENSION
LETS GO.

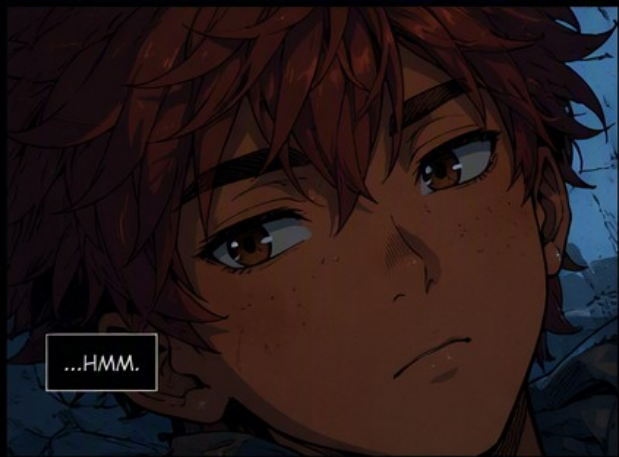
THE WORLD
HOLDS ITS
BREATH.



NOTHING
BREAKS.



I JUST...
COME BACK.



...HMM.



OKAY.



GUESS I'M
BACK IN MY
BODY.

RENN.

DAY ONE OF FREEDOM.
10:17 P.M.

NO SHIMMER.

NO PRESSURE.

JUST
SILENCE...

THE FIELD
IS GONE.



FORT VANGUARD
DETENTION LEVEL 3

CELL BLOCK C-22

FORTY-TWO DAYS.
NO CONTACT.
NO PRIVILEGES.
NO PROGRESS.

THEY PUT ME HERE
TO LET ME RUST.

THEY FORGOT
I DON'T RUST.
I REWIRE.



SHHHTTK



HUH?

...WHAT
THE—?

THE DOOR OPENS
NOT BECAUSE THEY
TRUST ME—

BUT BECAUSE THEY
KNOW I'LL WALK
THROUGH IT
ANYWAY.



TENSION-GAUNTLET:
SPOOL FULL.
FOCUS CLEAR.
FUTURE LOADED.

LET'S SEE WHAT'S
BEYOND THEIR WALLS.

Holdings are
built for patience.

I've never had
much of it.

ANCHORITE VANGUARD FACILITY // ZENITH PLATES

...

Hey.

You're
coming with
me.

Why?

Because this
place is a mausoleum.

And you're
not dead yet.

I see.

Your arm...

We move
without noise.

Not out of fear—
out of respect.

The Vanguard
builds walls.

We build
ways out.

Freedom isn't loud.

It just
opens.

Somewhere beyond the Plateau,
we'll decide who we're becoming.

Together.



SWING-CLIPPER
"GOLDEN SPIRAL"